



Making Your Web Apps Social with Facebook

Thinking about making your Web application talk to Facebook? Or do you need tighter integration for your website? Alternately, do you just want to do more with it than any third-party plug-in can provide? If you dream of doing all of the above, yourself, then read on!

Let's face it, a lot of us spend a significant portion of our lives on Facebook—it's one of those addictions that never seem to go away. To fuel this addiction and widen the reach of your Web application, developers need to make their apps social. This not only provides a good platform to the huge user base that Facebook has, but also allows you to get easy feedback about your brand, immediately. Also, if you need to, you can provide personalised information and services to users, tailored specifically to their likes and interests—and who knows, you can build an app specifically for the advanced statistical analysis of your users.

For basic users though, most CMS platforms today already have a few good plug-ins that work well with Facebook; all you need to do is install and enable them. Moreover, the Facebook documentation is so detailed that you don't even need to read this article if you are a basic user. But what if you are building your Web application right from scratch? What if you want it to be more tightly integrated than what those plug-ins can provide for? Yes, you need to get your hands dirty... so let's get started!

When you begin thinking about integrating your brand with Facebook, you are probably considering the following methods:

- Getting a *Like* button, a *Comments* box, an activity feed, etc, on your website, so that users can interact with your page easily.
- Getting a 'Log in with Facebook' button, in order to simplify the registration and login process.
- Getting an application on *facebook.com* that can access functionality such as *Requests*, *Events* and *Wall-posts*.

- Building a mobile application on a platform such as Android.

I'll try to give you a preview of how to get started with each of the above features. Using the *Like* button and other such social plug-ins involves just copying already 'cooked' code from the Facebook developer website, which provides GUI configuration options for each of these plug-ins—so we will mainly focus on Facebook application development, the Graph API, Open Graph protocol, FQL and other such features.

To start with, we need to register our application/website with Facebook, and get an application ID, along with a secret key. Head over to <https://www.facebook.com/developers/> and click the 'Set up New App' button to get started.

Social plug-ins

Social plug-ins are what Facebook provides for its easy integration with your website in the form of various features such as the *Like* button, *Login* button, *Registration* plug-in, *Recommendations*, the *Comments* box, etc. Now, let's say that you want to implement the 'Log in with Facebook' functionality in your Web application. As an example, let's try to make an application that greets the users by their names, as soon as they log in. The client-side code for such an application would be as follows:

```
<html xmlns="http://www.w3.org/1999/xhtml" xmlns:fb="http://www.facebook.com/2008/fbml">
<body>
<div id="fb-root"></div>
```